Settle in Germany — Design Brief (Web, Android, iOS)

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Product overview

Settle in Germany (working title) guides Nepali and Indian students, and later trainees and skilled workers, from admission to their first years in Germany. Design one product across three surfaces: a responsive website, an Android app and an iOS app.

Core promise: "Know exactly what to do next in Germany, in your language."

Primary users

Persona	Situation	Main need	Device
Priya, 23, Indian master's applicant	Admitted, still in Pune	Order of steps: APS, blocked account, visa	Android phone, laptop
Sujan, 24, Nepali student	First week in Leipzig	Address registration, bank, insurance, a letter he can't read	Android phone
Anjali, 27, Indian graduate	Finishing studies in Munich	Job search, CV, job-seeker permit	iPhone, laptop
Bikash, 30, Nepali skilled worker	Moving with family	Residence permit, renting, family paperwork	Android phone

Most users are on mid-range Android phones and often on slow or prepaid data. Design mobile-first, light on data, and fast on low-end devices.

Business model the design must support

- **Free tier with ads:** all guides, checklists, reminders, city pages, calculators and comparisons.
- **Premium subscription:** all AI features and no ads. Suggested price €3.99 a month or €29.99 a year, with a 7-day trial.
- **Affiliate comparisons:** referral links to blocked accounts, insurers, banks, phone plans and money-transfer services, clearly labelled.

Design goals

1. **Calm and trustworthy:** users are often stressed by bureaucracy. The app should feel official-grade, not salesy.
2. **Always show the next step:** every screen answers "what do I do now?"
3. **Multilingual from day one:** English, Nepali and Hindi interface, with German terms always shown alongside.
4. **Premium feels useful, not pushy:** AI features are discoverable at the moment of need, never blocking free information.
5. **Accessible:** WCAG 2.2 AA, large tap targets, readable on small screens.

Brand and visual direction

The look should feel like a calm, competent friend who has done it all before: clear, warm and reliable, never like a government form or a flashy startup.

Personality: reassuring, practical, culturally familiar. Small touches can reference South Asian and German everyday life (a chai cup, a tram, a stack of letters), but avoid flags, clichés and tourist imagery.

Colour (starting proposal, open to Claude Design's judgement)

Role	Proposal	Use
Primary	Deep teal (#0F5C63)	Main actions, active navigation, progress
Accent	Warm saffron (#E8A33D)	Highlights, premium badge, celebrations of completed steps
Success	Green (#2E7D4F)	Completed steps, valid documents
Warning	Amber (#B7791F)	Deadlines within 30 days
Danger	Red (#B42318)	Deadlines within 7 days, expired documents, scam alerts
Neutral	Warm greys	Text, surfaces, dividers

The palette must pass WCAG AA contrast in both light and dark mode. Never use colour alone to show status; pair it with an icon and a word.

Typography

- Latin script: a highly legible sans serif with good number shapes, for example Inter or Source Sans 3.
- Devanagari (Nepali and Hindi): Noto Sans Devanagari or Mukta, matched in weight and size so mixed-script lines look even.
- Devanagari needs about 10–15% more line height than Latin text. Test long Nepali words and conjuncts in buttons and tabs.
- German terms appear in a consistent style (for example medium weight with a small "DE" tag), so users learn to recognise official words like *Anmeldung* or *Aufenthaltstitel*.

Iconography and illustration

- One outline icon set (for example Lucide or Material Symbols) used consistently on all platforms.
- Simple, friendly spot illustrations for empty states, onboarding and stage headers. Diverse South Asian characters, flat style, limited palette.
- Each journey stage (Before arrival, First 30 days, Living, Career) gets its own small illustration and a subtle tint.

Dark mode: required on all three platforms, following the system setting with a manual override.

Accessibility: WCAG 2.2 AA, support for system text size up to 200%, screen-reader labels on every control, minimum touch targets of 44×44 pt (iOS) and 48×48 dp (Android), and reduced-motion support.

Platforms and layout

One shared design system, adapted to each platform's conventions so the apps feel native rather than identical.

	Web	Android	iOS
Guidelines	Responsive, mobile-first	Material Design 3	Apple Human Interface Guidelines
Main navigation	Top bar on desktop; bottom tab bar on mobile web	Bottom navigation bar, 5 destinations	Tab bar, 5 tabs

	Web	Android	iOS
Back navigation	Browser back, breadcrumbs on guide pages	System back gesture	Swipe-back and back button with title
Typography base	16 px body	Roboto-scale sizes with chosen brand font	SF-scale sizes with chosen brand font, Dynamic Type
Sheets and dialogs	Modal dialogs, side panel on desktop	Bottom sheets, Material dialogs	Sheets with detents, action sheets
Camera (letter explainer)	File upload and phone camera on mobile web	Native camera with document edge detection	Native document scanner (VisionKit)
Payments	Stripe checkout	Google Play Billing	App Store in-app purchase
Ads	Google AdSense	Google AdMob	Google AdMob

Web breakpoints

- Small (under 600 px): single column, bottom tab bar, same layout as the apps.
- Medium (600–1023 px): two columns where useful, for example guide list and guide content.
- Large (1024 px and up): top navigation, guide pages with a sticky table of contents on the left and related tools on the right; maximum content width about 720 px for reading.

The website has a second job: search traffic. Guide pages must be public, fast and readable without logging in, with clean headings, a visible "last verified" date and source links. Most new users will land on a single guide page from Google, so every guide page needs a clear path into the app: "Get your personal checklist" and app-store badges.

Offline: guides the user has opened, their roadmap and reminders must work offline in the apps. Show a subtle offline banner, not an error screen.

Information architecture

Five main destinations, the same on all platforms. The centre tab is the AI hub, so the premium features are always one tap away without interrupting the free content.

Tab	Contains	Tier
Home	Personal roadmap, next 3 steps, upcoming deadlines, rule-change alerts, stage progress	Free
Guides	All guides grouped by journey stage, search, saved guides, city pages	Free
Assist (centre, highlighted)	Letter explainer (camera), reply writer, assistant chat, scam checker, contract explainer, form assistant, job kit, conversation practice	Premium (with limited free trials)
Tools	Budget calculator, net-pay calculator, work-limit tracker, comparisons (blocked account, insurance, banks, phone, money transfer), phrasebook, emergency contacts	Free
Me	Reminders and document dates, profile and stage, language, subscription, notifications, privacy and data, help	Free

Journey stages organise the roadmap and the guides. Every guide and checklist item belongs to one stage:

1. **Before arrival:** APS, blocked account, health insurance for the visa, visa appointment, packing, first housing.
2. **First 30 days:** address registration, bank account, tax ID, phone plan, transit pass, enrolment, broadcasting fee, residence-permit appointment.
3. **Living in Germany:** work rules, student jobs, health system, renting, driving licence, taxes, sending money home.
4. **Career and staying on:** CV, job search, job-seeker permit, Blue Card, permanent residence, citizenship basics.

The user's profile sets their current stage. They can view any stage, but the Home tab focuses on the current one.

Global elements on every screen

- Search (guides, tools and German terms), reachable from Home and Guides.
- Language switcher in Me and in the onboarding; changes apply instantly.
- Ad slots only in the free tier and only where the Monetization section allows.

Free feature screens

Each screen below lists its purpose, content and main actions. Design light and dark variants, and mobile and desktop where the web layout differs.

1. Welcome and onboarding (4–5 steps)

- **Welcome:** app name, one-line promise, language choice (English, नेपाली, हिन्दी), "Get started" and "I already have an account".
- **Profile questions, one per screen with large tap options:** nationality (Nepal, India, other), status (student, vocational trainee, skilled worker, family member), city (searchable list, or "not decided yet"), stage (still at home, arrived recently, living here over 3 months, finishing studies), arrival date (date picker, optional).
- **Notifications permission:** explain the benefit first ("We'll remind you before your visa expires"), then the system prompt.
- **Account:** optional at this point. Sign in with Google, Apple or email, or "Continue without account" (data stays on the device).
- **Result:** "Your roadmap is ready" with the first three steps.

Show a progress indicator. Every step can be skipped and changed later in Me.

2. Home (personal roadmap)

- **Header:** greeting, current stage with a progress ring ("First 30 days: 4 of 9 done").
- **Next steps card:** the next 3 open tasks, each with a deadline chip and a "How to" link to its guide.
- **Upcoming deadlines:** up to 3 items coloured by urgency (over 30 days neutral, within 30 days amber, within 7 days red), each with icon and word.
- **Rule-change alert banner** when a relevant rule changes, dismissible.
- **Assist shortcut:** "Got a letter you don't understand? Scan it" (opens the letter explainer or its paywall).
- **Stage switcher** to preview other stages.
- One native ad slot below the fold in the free tier.

3. Roadmap detail (checklist)

- Full list of tasks for a stage, grouped (for example "Paperwork", "Money", "Health").
- Each task: checkbox, title, German term, deadline, estimated time, link to its guide.
- Ticking a task shows a small celebration in the accent colour and updates the progress ring.
- Users can add their own tasks and hide tasks that don't apply.

4. Guides list and search

- Stage filter chips, a search bar, and a "Saved" filter.
- Guide cards: title, German term, reading time, "last verified" date, and an icon if the guide has a related tool or comparison.
- Search results also match German words and common misspellings (for example "anmeldung", "anmeldun").

5. Guide page (the most important template)

- **Top:** title, German term with audio pronunciation, reading time, "last verified on [date]", save and share buttons.
- **Summary box:** "In short" with 3 lines: what it is, when you need it, the deadline.
- **Steps:** numbered steps, each with documents needed, where to go, typical cost, and typical waiting time.
- **Documents checklist:** tickable, can be added to the user's roadmap in one tap.
- **Callouts:** tip (teal), warning (amber), common mistake (red), with icons.
- **Related:** tools, comparison pages and other guides.
- **Official sources:** list of links at the end.
- **Contextual AI prompt** at the end: "Need help writing to the office? Use the reply writer."
- **Feedback:** "Was this helpful?" and "Report outdated information".
- Web: sticky table of contents on desktop; app-store badges and a "Get your personal checklist" call to action.
- Ads: one inline slot after the summary box and one before the sources, never inside the steps.

6. City page

- Header image or illustration of the city, key facts (typical rent range, transit pass).
- How to book immigration-office and citizen's-office appointments, with official links and tips.
- Community and culture: Nepali and Indian grocery stores, restaurants, temples and community groups, shown as a list with map pins.
- "Report a change" button on each entry.

7. Reminders and document dates (in Me)

- List of tracked items: visa, residence permit, passport, health insurance, semester fee, tax deadline, custom reminders.
- Each item: name, expiry date, days remaining, status colour with icon and word.
- Add or edit sheet: type, date, reminder schedule (default 90, 30 and 7 days before), optional note.
- The free tier stores dates and notes only, no document images. Say so clearly on the screen.

8. Calculators (in Tools)

- **Monthly budget:** pick city and living situation, adjust rent, food, insurance, transit and phone; result as a total with a simple breakdown bar.
- **Net pay for student jobs:** hourly wage and hours, result with a plain explanation of deductions.
- **Work-limit tracker:** log work days, show used and remaining allowance with a progress bar and an amber warning near the limit. Limits come from the content system so they can be updated when rules change.

9. Comparison pages (in Tools)

- Categories: blocked accounts, health insurance, bank accounts, phone plans, money transfer to Nepal and India.
- Layout: short explainer of what matters, then provider cards with the key facts as aligned rows (fees, opening time, payout terms), and a "Visit provider" button.
- Label every referral link ("Referral link: we may earn a commission at no cost to you").
- Sort options must include one that isn't based on commission, for example "Lowest fees".

- Money-transfer comparison: amount input, live rate and fee per provider, total received, and a rate-alert toggle.

10. Phrasebook

- Situations: immigration office, citizen's office, doctor, pharmacy, landlord, bank, workplace.
- Each phrase: German, transliteration, English or Nepali or Hindi meaning, audio button, favourite star.

11. Safety and emergency

- Large tiles for emergency numbers (112, 110, 116117), each tap-to-call.
- Embassy and consulate contacts for Nepal and India.
- Scam warning library with real examples and "what to do".

12. Rule-change alerts

- List of alerts, newest first, each with date, affected group ("Students from India"), a 2-line summary and a link to the updated guide.
- Alerts are shown on Home and sent as push notifications only when they affect the user's profile.

Premium AI feature screens

All AI features live in the **Assist** tab and can also be opened from relevant guides. Every AI screen must show a small "AI" label, explain that answers are general information, and offer a path to human help for individual legal questions.

Assist hub

- Large primary card: **"Scan a letter"** with a camera icon.
- Grid of feature tiles: reply writer, ask a question, scam checker, contract explainer, form assistant, job kit, conversation practice.
- Free users see a "3 free scans left this month" counter and a premium badge on locked tiles. Locked tiles open the paywall, not an error.
- Recent activity: last explained letters and drafted replies (premium only, stored only if the user opts in).

1. Letter explainer (main hook)

Flow: capture → processing → result → actions.

- **Capture:** camera with automatic edge detection, multi-page support, retake and crop; also "Upload PDF or photo".
- **Privacy note on the capture screen:** "Your document is processed and then deleted. We don't keep it unless you choose to save it."
- **Processing:** a calm progress state with steps ("Reading the letter", "Finding deadlines", "Preparing your summary"), no playful animations.
- **Result screen sections, in this order:**
  1. **Who sent it and what it is**, with sender type (for example immigration office, health insurer, tax office).
  2. **What they want from you**, in 1–3 plain sentences.
  3. **Deadline**, large and coloured by urgency, with an "Add to reminders" button.
  4. **What to do next**, as a numbered checklist.
  5. **Key terms**, with German words explained.
  6. **Show original text** (collapsible), with side-by-side German and translation.
- **Actions:** "Write a reply" (opens the reply writer with context), "Ask a follow-up question", "Related guide", "Save", "Share summary".
- **Warning state:** if the letter looks urgent or legal (for example a deportation or court notice), show a red banner recommending immediate human help, with links to migration counselling services.

2. Reply writer

- Inputs: recipient type, purpose (dropdown: request appointment, send documents, ask for extension, object, cancel, other), key details in the user's own language.
- Output: formal German letter or email with a translation shown alongside.
- Tone toggle (formal / very formal), "Make it shorter", "Add a detail".
- Actions: copy, open in email app, export as PDF with correct German letter layout (sender, recipient, date, subject line).

3. Ask a question (assistant chat)

- Chat interface with suggested questions based on the user's stage.
- Answers cite the guide they come from as tappable chips.

- When a question needs individual legal advice, the answer says so and shows a card with official help options.
- Language follows the app setting; the user can ask in English, Nepali or Hindi.

4. Housing scam checker

- Input: paste a listing or message, or upload screenshots.
- Output: a risk level (low, medium, high) with icon and word, a list of specific red flags found, and what to do next.
- Never says "safe". Low risk is phrased as "no common warning signs found".

5. Rental contract explainer

- Upload a contract (multi-page).
- Output: clause-by-clause plain-language summary, with common problem clauses flagged in amber and an explanation of why they matter.
- A fixed notice: "This is general information, not legal advice. For your specific case, contact a tenants' association or lawyer."

6. Form assistant

- Pick a form (address registration, residence-permit application, and others).
- Field-by-field walkthrough: the German field label, a plain explanation, an example answer, and the user's answer.
- Output: a summary sheet the user can copy into the official form or print.

7. Job application kit

- **CV builder:** German-style CV template with photo option, sections, and a live preview; export as PDF.
- **Cover letter:** paste a job ad, get a tailored German or English cover letter.
- **Interview practice:** text or voice; the AI asks questions for the role and gives feedback after each answer.

8. Conversation practice

- Pick a scenario (immigration office, doctor, flat viewing, workplace small talk) and a level (beginner, intermediate).
- Voice or text role-play with the AI playing the official or landlord.

- After the session: corrections, useful phrases, and a "practise again" button.

Monetization screens

Monetization must never block free information or feel like a trick. Users who feel tricked leave and warn their community groups.

Paywall

- Opened from a locked AI tile, after the free scans run out, or from Me → Subscription.
- **Content:** headline tied to the moment ("Understand every German letter in seconds"), 4–5 benefits with icons, plan cards (monthly €3.99, yearly €29.99 marked "Save 37%"), "Start 7-day free trial", and the price after the trial stated clearly.
- **Required details:** cancel-anytime note, how to cancel, restore purchases (apps), terms and privacy links.
- Easy to close with a visible X; no countdown timers or fake scarcity.
- Platform-specific purchase sheets: Google Play, App Store, Stripe on web.

Free trial uses

- Free users get 3 letter scans a month. Show the remaining count before they start a scan, not after.
- After the last free scan, the result still shows in full, followed by a soft upgrade card.

Premium status

- Small saffron "Premium" badge in Me and on the Assist hub.
- Subscription screen: plan, renewal date, usage this month, manage or cancel (opens the store's subscription page).

Ad rules (free tier only)

Placement	Allowed format	Notes
Home, below the fold	Native ad card	Styled like a card, labelled "Ad"
Guide page, after the summary box	Banner or native	Never inside steps or checklists

Placement	Allowed format	Notes
Guide page, before sources	Banner or native	
Guides list	Native card every 8 items	
Tools results	Banner below results	Never between input and result
AI screens, paywall, onboarding, emergency, document dates	None	

No pop-up, interstitial or video ads that interrupt a task. Every ad is clearly labelled "Ad". Block categories such as payday loans, gambling, unlicensed immigration agents and "guaranteed visa" offers (configured in the ad network, but design the slots assuming clean, calm ads).

Referral labelling

- Every referral link carries a visible label: "Referral link: we may earn a commission at no cost to you."
- A short "How we make money" page, linked from comparison pages and Me.

Consent (EU)

- A consent banner on first launch and first web visit, before any personalised ads or non-essential tracking.
- Options of equal visual weight: "Accept all", "Reject all", "Settings".
- Consent can be changed any time in Me → Privacy.
- Use a certified consent tool; the design should match its required elements.

Design system: components and states

Build one token-based system (colour, type, spacing, radius, elevation) with platform variants, so the web, Android and iOS versions stay consistent and can be themed later.

Tokens: spacing on a 4-point scale, corner radius 8–16 for cards and 999 for chips, two elevation levels, and the colour and type roles from the brand section, each with light and dark values.

Core components

Component	Variants	Notes
Button	Primary, secondary, text, destructive, premium (saffron)	Loading state; full-width on mobile
Task item	Open, done, overdue, hidden	Checkbox, title, German term, deadline chip, guide link
Deadline chip	Neutral, warning, danger, done	Always icon + word, not colour alone
German term tag	Inline, with audio	Consistent style everywhere
Guide card	Default, saved, updated recently	Shows "last verified" date
Callout	Tip, warning, common mistake, legal notice	Icon + coloured edge
Provider card (comparison)	Default, highlighted, referral	Aligned fact rows, referral label
Progress ring and bar	Stage progress, work-limit	
AI result block	Summary, deadline, next steps, key terms, original text	"AI" label in the header
Premium lock	Tile overlay, inline card	Opens paywall
Ad slot	Banner, native card	"Ad" label, fixed size to avoid layout shift
Alert banner	Info, rule change, urgent	Dismissible except urgent
Bottom sheet / modal	Add reminder, share, filters	
Chat bubble	User, AI, AI with source chips, legal-help card	

States every screen needs

- **Empty:** friendly illustration, one sentence, one action ("No reminders yet. Add your visa expiry date").

- **Loading:** skeleton screens for lists and guides; step-by-step progress for AI processing.
- **Error:** plain explanation and a retry button; never a raw error code.
- **Offline:** subtle banner, cached content still usable; AI features show "Needs internet".
- **Limit reached:** for free scans, a soft upgrade card that still shows the current result.
- **Outdated content:** a banner on a guide when its verification is older than 6 months ("We're re-checking this guide").

Content, microcopy and legal UI

Voice: short sentences, plain words, second person ("you"), calm even for urgent topics. Explain every German term the first time it appears. Avoid jargon such as "KYC" or "onboarding" in the interface.

Examples

Instead of	Write
"Error 403: request failed"	"We couldn't load this. Check your connection and try again."
"Unlock premium features now!"	"Get help with every letter you receive."
"Your document is compliant"	"No common problems found. For your exact case, ask the office directly."
"Deadline approaching"	"Your visa expires in 21 days. Book your appointment now."

Multilingual layout rules

- Design every screen with the longest language. Nepali and Hindi strings are often 20–40% longer than English and need extra line height.
- Buttons and tabs must allow two lines of text without breaking the layout.
- Dates use the Gregorian calendar with German formats explained (for example "14.03.2027" shown as "14 March 2027").

Legal elements the design must include

- **Imprint (Impressum) and privacy policy:** linked in the web footer and in Me on all platforms.

- **General-information notice:** a short line on guides and every AI result: "General information, not legal advice." Individual legal questions link to a "Where to get help" page (migration counselling, student services, tenants' associations, lawyers).
- **AI label:** every AI-generated answer is visibly marked as AI.
- **Referral disclosure:** on every referral link, plus the "How we make money" page.
- **Consent controls:** in onboarding and in Me → Privacy.
- **Data controls:** Me → Privacy shows what is stored, "Download my data" and "Delete my account".
- **Age:** a minimum-age confirmation (16+) in account creation.
- **Source and date on every guide:** official links and the "last verified" date.

Deliverables for Claude Design

Design in three rounds, so the core look is agreed before every screen is drawn.

Round 1: direction (start here)

1. Two or three visual directions shown on the same three screens: Home, a guide page, and the letter-explainer result.
2. Colour, type (Latin and Devanagari) and icon choices for the chosen direction, in light and dark mode.

Round 2: version 1 screens

- Onboarding (all steps), Home, roadmap detail, guides list, guide page, reminders, comparison page (blocked accounts), Assist hub, letter explainer (capture, processing, result), reply writer, paywall, consent banner.
- Each on Android and iOS at phone size, and the web versions of Home, guide page, comparison page and paywall at mobile and desktop widths.
- Light and dark mode, and one screen each in Nepali and Hindi to check text length.

Round 3: remaining screens and the system

- City page, calculators, phrasebook, safety, alerts, assistant chat, scam checker, contract explainer, form assistant, job kit, conversation practice, Me and settings.
- The component library with all variants and states from the design-system section.
- Empty, loading, error, offline and limit-reached states for the main screens.

Sample content to use in designs

- Guide: "Register your address (Anmeldung)", deadline "within 2 weeks of moving in", stage "First 30 days".
- Letter: a letter from the immigration office asking for documents within 14 days.
- User: Sujan, Nepali student in Leipzig, 4 of 9 first-month steps done, residence-permit appointment in 21 days.

Out of scope for now: community question-and-answer, job board, and countries other than Germany. Leave room in the navigation and design system to add them later.